By Taylor Burke · November 7, 2026 · A personal project from public data, not a product of the Food Bank of Eastern Oklahoma

After 5pm and on Saturdays, about half of Tulsa's highest-need neighborhoods can't reach an open pantry without a car.

Tulsa County's 52 highest-need census tracts are home to 154,000 people, 46,000 of them below the poverty line. Walking and riding the bus, 30 minutes door to door, almost all of them can get to an open food pantry on a weekday. Most pantries close by 5pm and few open on Saturday, so about ten times as many people in poverty are left without one on a Saturday as on a weekday.

WEEKDAY DAYTIME

5%

of high-need residents can't reach an open pantry

53 of 69 pantries open · ≈2,200 people in poverty left out

WEEKDAY EVENING (AFTER 5PM)

46%

of high-need residents can't reach an open pantry

17 of 69 pantries open · ≈21,000 people in poverty left out

SATURDAY

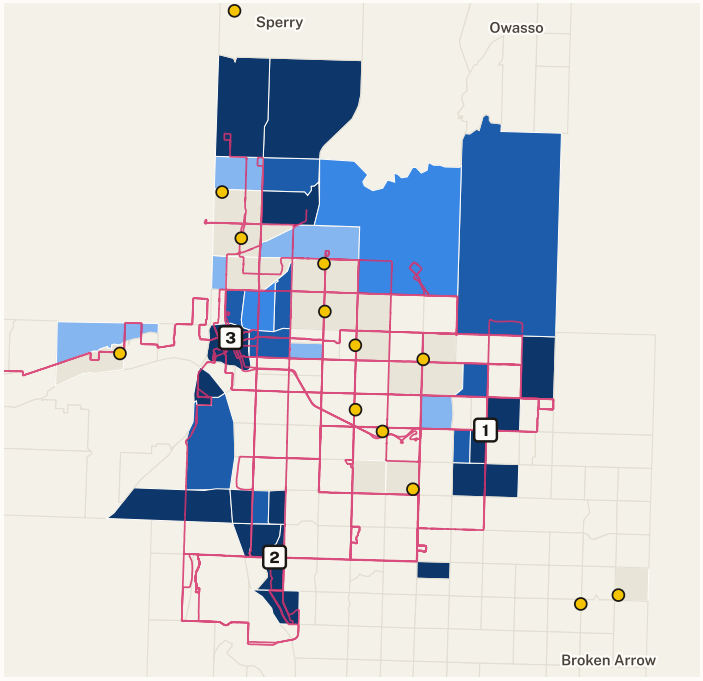
50%

of high-need residents can't reach an open pantry

12 of 69 pantries open · ≈23,000 people in poverty left out

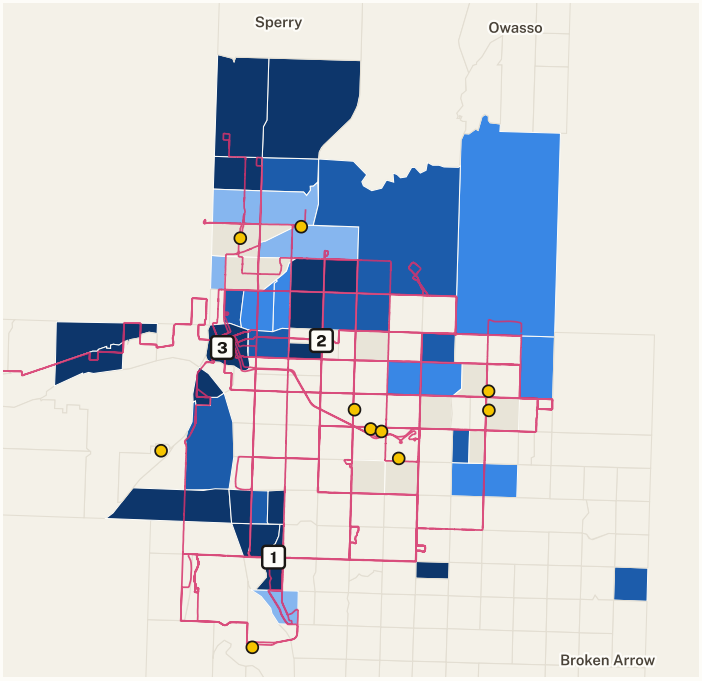
Weekday evening (after 5pm)

17 of 69 county pantries open · 54% of high-need residents can reach one



Saturday

12 of 69 county pantries open · 50% of high-need residents can reach one



Shading: number of people in poverty in each high-need tract who can't reach an open pantry within 30 min

0 people · 1–99 · 100–299 · 300–599 · 600+ people · Not high-need · Pantry open · 1 Mobile site, page 2 · Bus route

How it's measured

Trips start from every 2020 census block: walking at 3 mph (straight-line distance × 1.3) plus scheduled Tulsa Transit service with at most one transfer, from the published timetable. Riders who check the schedule wait 5 minutes for the first bus. A full trip planner (R5) gives the same reachable-or-not answer for 93%–95% of residents. Supply is every general-public pantry on the Food Bank's public Food Finder, with its posted hours; school, senior-only and meal programs are left out, and service-area rules are applied where a listing states them.

Maps show the Tulsa urban area, which holds all 52 high-need tracts. High-need: the top quarter of county tracts on poverty, households without a car and SNAP use (2020–24 American Community Survey). Pantries: general-public pantries on the Food Bank's public Food Finder with a regular session in the window.

Where the gap is biggest

The ten high-need tracts with the most people in poverty who can't reach an open pantry on a Saturday. The clearest case is E 61st St & Peoria Ave: on a weekday the nearest open pantry is 0.4 km away. After 5pm it is 7.2 km, and on a Saturday 5.0 km.

#	Where (nearest arterials)	Poverty	No car	Share who can reach one Weekday	Evening	Sat	People in poverty, none in reach on Sat
1	E 61st St & Peoria Ave tract 68.01	47%	28%	100%	0%	0%	**1,638**
2	E Apache St & Harvard Ave tract 3	36%	10%	100%	100%	29%	**1,133**
3	E 21st St tract 46	39%	24%	100%	0%	0%	**1,071**
4	E 61st St & Peoria Ave tract 76.08	44%	25%	100%	0%	0%	**985**
5	W 61st St & 33rd W Ave tract 67.01	32%	10%	47%	0%	0%	**983**
6	E 81st St & Utica Ave tract 76.41	21%	14%	100%	0%	10%	**971**
7	Cincinnati Ave tract 91.01	38%	10%	85%	15%	15%	**855**
8	E Archer St tract 14	28%	6%	100%	100%	42%	**830**
9	E 11th St & 49th W Ave tract 88	36%	9%	100%	100%	0%	**817**
10	E 81st St & Mingo Rd tract 76.46	23%	21%	88%	0%	0%	**758**

Also in the weekday-evening top ten (people in poverty with none in reach): E 31st St & 129th East Ave (tract 73.06, 1,409); E 41st St & Mingo Rd (tract 90.08, 1,151); E 21st St (tract 73.11, 951).

Where a mobile distribution would help most

A first screening, not a recommendation. These are the bus stops where one mobile distribution would put the most people in poverty who have no open pantry today within 30 minutes of one, picked one at a time so each adds to the ones before it. It doesn't weigh parking, host sites, capacity or meal programs. They're the numbered squares on the maps.

Weekday evenings

1. **31st St & Garnett Rd** bus stop: about 10,000 more people in poverty within 30 min, mostly around E 31st St & 129th East Ave · E 41st St & 129th East Ave · E 41st St & Mingo Rd.
2. **71st St & Wheeling Dr** bus stop: about 9,900 more people in poverty within 30 min, mostly around E 61st St & Peoria Ave · E 81st St & Utica Ave.
3. **1st St & Cincinnati Ave** bus stop: about 5,300 more people in poverty within 30 min, mostly around E 11th St · E 21st St · E Archer St.

Together: about 25,000 of the 59,000 people in poverty countywide with no open pantry in reach.

Saturdays

1. **71st St & Wheeling Dr** bus stop: about 8,700 more people in poverty within 30 min, mostly around E 61st St & Peoria Ave · E 61st St & Utica Ave.
2. **4th St & Harvard Ave** bus stop: about 8,000 more people in poverty within 30 min, mostly around E 11th St · E Apache St & Harvard Ave · E Archer St.
3. **Denver Avenue Station** bus stop: about 3,600 more people in poverty within 30 min, mostly around E 11th St · E 21st St.

Together: about 20,000 of the 61,000 people in poverty countywide with no open pantry in reach.

What it can't tell you

- **Survey margins.** Tract figures come from a sample, so every rate on the map shows its 90% margin. 1 of the 19 tracts on any top-ten list has a measure with a wide margin.
- **Hours go stale.** Pantries post their own hours, and they change. 7 county pantries list none. Counting all of those as open in every window lifts the Saturday share in high-need tracts from 50% to 73%, an upper bound.
- **The bus is a model.** Scheduled service only, from the feed valid Sep 10, 2026 to Dec 5, 2026. No late buses, no trip home, no groceries to carry, and walking is measured in straight lines.
- **Tracts are averages.** Need is a tract average and hides pockets inside better-off tracts. Access is worked out block by block, but those block populations date from 2020.
- **Not every pantry.** Only the public Food Finder's listings: school, senior and meal programs are left out, and pantries outside the Food Bank's network are missing.

Interactive map, every pantry's hours and the full method:
tulsa-pantry-gap.pages.dev

Code and data pipeline: github.com/TaylorBurke/tulsa-pantry-gap

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